

Above Little Gap

by Douglass Burley Johnson

Hand me that split oak. The pines on this side of Blue Mountain stand so tall and close you could mistake them for men if the fire got low and you weren't careful. I want the light high before I tell this one, because this one is about tall ones who really walked, and about a boy who had to decide what to do with his feet when they did.

I was fourteen the October my church youth group overnighted in a rented cabin above Little Gap, up where the Appalachian Trail cuts the ridge and the wind comes hard off the Lehigh. Our youth pastor's father came along to keep the stove lit and the boys from wrestling through the drywall. His name was Mr. Kovacs. He had worked roofs in the Slate Belt until his knees quit, and he still carried a folding rule in his shirt pocket the way other men carry pens. That first night he sat on a stump at the fire ring with a dented thermos between his boots and a blue plastic fork half-melted into the ash at the ring's edge, left by whoever rented the place the week before, and he listened to us talk.

Somebody said the giants in Genesis were metaphors. Somebody else said they were cartoons for people who hadn't got science yet. I kept my mouth shut, because my grandfather had told me a different story every deer season since I was nine, and I had believed him, and I didn't know how to say that to a circle of kids roasting marshmallows without sounding like I was twelve.

Mr. Kovacs screwed the thermos lid down with his thumb and said, "They weren't metaphors." He said it the way he'd say a rafter was out of square. Then he told us what his own father had told him, and what that man's father had told him before that, which is the way these things travel when nobody writes them down careful. I'm going to tell it the way it sat in me that night, because the pines were listening, and so was I.

In the days when men multiplied on the earth, long before any of our mountains had names, there lived a boy called Adon in a settlement of timber and mudbrick down in a wide river valley. His father cut cypress and gopher wood under contract for a man named Noah, who was building a vessel so large the neighbors came out to laugh at it and then went home uneasy. Adon's mother kept a garden of onions and bitter greens, and she braided Adon's sister's hair with red clay worked into the ends so the plaits held. Adon was twelve the year he first understood that the tall shining ones who came down at dusk were not visitors from a friendly court.

He was digging tubers behind the house that evening, red clay packed under his fingernails, when the sky went white without thunder. A smell like struck metal rolled down the valley. Out of that white a figure walked, and the figure had the shape of a man, and he was beautiful the way a blade is beautiful, and he was taller than Adon's father by a head and then some. He did not ask leave at any door. He went into the house of a widow at the settlement's

edge, and in the morning the widow was gone, and her door stood open, and the neighbors would not go near it for three days.

Adon's father came home from Noah's yard with pitch on his forearms and said, "The sons of God left their post." He said it quiet, over supper, with his eyes on the bowl. "They were set to watch over us. They wanted the daughters instead. We call it what it is. Theft. And what they breed will not be ours."

Adon's mother set her spoon down. "People say they're a blessing. People say the children will be mighty."

"People say a lot of things while the roof is still on," Adon's father said. He wiped his hands on a rag and did not eat the rest of his supper.

The first of the children born from those unions grew wrong. Adon saw one at the market two years later, when he was fourteen and tall enough to see over the grain sacks. The boy was already the height of a grown man, and his hands hung large and wrong at his wrists, and when he laughed the sound ran along the stalls and made the dogs put their tails down. Men called him renown. Men called him a gift. Adon watched him step on a copper bracelet somebody had dropped in the mud and flatten it without looking down, the way you'd flatten a leaf, and Adon put his own hand in his pocket and held onto the little knife his father had given him for stripping bark.

Years went that way. More of the shining ones came down. More women left and came back carrying what they carried, or did not come back. The children of those unions grew into giants, and the giants grew hungry, and the hunger turned mean. Fields that had fed a settlement for a generation were stripped in a week. Men who argued were broken. Adon heard it said, later, that when the flocks and the grain were gone the tall ones turned on flesh, and he believed it

without needing the details. Violence filled the earth the way floodwater fills a low street, quiet at the edges and then everywhere at once.

Through all of it, Noah's hammer kept time.

Adon went with his father to the yard when he turned fifteen. The vessel stood on a frame of shored timber, higher than the settlement's meeting house, longer than the market street. Men moved on its ribs like ants. The air smelled of fresh cut and of the black pitch Noah's sons boiled in iron pots and brushed into every seam. A bee had stuck itself in a patch of pitch on a low plank near the ladder, wings still, and Adon looked at it longer than he needed to, because looking at the bee was easier than looking at the size of what Noah was building.

Noah himself was older than Adon's grandfather, and he preached while he worked, and he did not preach pretty. The Lord had given the earth a hundred and twenty years to turn around, Noah told them, and the years were running, and anybody with ears could hear the clock in every hammer blow. The Lord was grieved down to His heart. All flesh had corrupted its way, Noah said, looking past the scoffers at the fence to the men who still had pitch on their hands.

"You can laugh," Noah said, "or you can pick up a tool."

Adon's father picked up a tool every morning. Adon's mother packed them bread and onions and did not laugh, and did not come to the yard either, because she had a sister who had gone with one of the shining ones in the second year and had sent back word once, proud, about a son who could already break a plow handle in his fists, and then had sent no word at all.

The hundred and twenty years were a count in that valley. Old men scratched the count on doorposts. Children learned it the way children learn the names of rivers. Adon scratched his own marks on the underside of his sleeping shelf, one scratch a season, and when he ran his

thumb over the row in the dark the marks sat closer together than they had the year before. He tied his sandals and went to work. Pity never drove a peg.

One evening in the last handful of those years, a giant came through the settlement looking for grain that was already gone. Adon was at the well with his sister. The giant's head cleared the eaves of the houses. His spear was a peeled sapling with a head of beaten bronze as wide as a platter. He asked for the stores in a voice that made the water in the well ring, and when the headman said the stores were empty the giant put the butt of the spear through the headman's door and walked into the house to see for himself.

Adon's sister made a sound and started toward their own door. Adon caught her wrist.

"To the yard," he said. "Now."

They ran. Behind them somebody screamed, and then wood broke, and then there was the heavy sound of a body that had found no grain and had decided to be angry about it. Adon did not look back. He had his sister's wrist and the little bark knife and the Name his father had taught him to say when his feet wanted to stop, and he said that Name under his breath on the path all the way to the fence.

They reached Noah's fence at full dark. Noah's sons were hanging pitch lamps along the near rib. Animals moved in holding pens farther down, restless, two by two where they had been led. Adon's father was on a scaffold with a mallet. He saw them, came down the ladder without asking questions, and put Adon's sister behind him and his hand on Adon's shoulder hard enough to hurt.

"Inside the gate," he said. "Both of you."

That night Adon slept against a coil of rope that smelled like tar and river water, and his sister slept with her head on their father's knee, and the giant did not come as far as the yard. In

the morning there was smoke over the settlement, and Adon's mother came up the path with a bundle and a cut on her forearm she would not explain, and she walked through Noah's gate without looking back at the valley.

Noah found them at midday with pitch in his beard, and he looked at Adon the way a man looks at a rafter, checking whether it will bear.

"You ran the right direction," Noah said. "Most don't."

"Will you take us," Adon's mother asked. Her voice came out rough.

"The Lord told me who comes through that door when the time arrives," Noah said.

"Until then, anybody who will work and repent can stand in this yard and hear the truth. After the door shuts, the count is over."

Noah left them that, and he did not make it softer. Adon's father went back up the scaffold. Adon found a brush and a pot and started working pitch into a seam a man showed him, and he kept his eyes on the black line until his wrist ached.

The scoffers at the fence hollered that Noah was mad and that the tall ones would protect the valley better than any wooden box. One of the scoffers had a son by a woman who had been taken and returned, and that son was already famous in three settlements for what he could lift. Adon heard the boy's name shouted like a cheer. He kept his eyes on the seam and his mouth shut and his hand moving.

On a morning when the count on the old men's doorposts had run nearly out, the sky did the white thing again without thunder. Adon was on the scaffold beside his father. Down the valley, at the settlement's far edge, three figures stood where the road came in, and even at that distance Adon knew them for what they were: the fathers of giants, Watchers who had left their

proper domain, standing in stolen flesh that fit them too well. No wave, no call. Those three looked at the vessel the way a man looks at a fence he intends to settle with later.

Adon's father put his mallet down.

"Inside," he said.

"They're not coming this hour," Adon said.

"Inside anyway."

They went. Noah was at the great door with his hand on the frame, and the fear was not on him. He stood like a man who had been told the weather in advance and had built for it. Behind him, in the dim, animals shifted and grumbled. Adon's sister stood with her back against a crate of seed grain, and Adon's mother stood with her.

"In the name of the Lord who shut and who opens," Noah said, not loud, "you will not have this yard."

He was talking to the three on the road. Whether they heard it in their bodies or in whatever place a Watcher hears from, Adon could not say. He only saw them hold still a long time, and then turn, and then go back into the white that had brought them, as if a door in the air had been claimed by somebody with a better key.

That is the part my grandfather always told twice.

The rain began before the season's turn. First a smell, then a dark in the north, then water falling the way water had never fallen in living memory, because in those days the world was watered different and men had not seen the windows of heaven pulled open. Under the valley the deep places broke. Adon stood in Noah's yard with pitch on his hands and watched the settlement's roofs go under the first real weather they had ever known, and he understood, without a speech from anybody, why the vessel had needed to be high.

Did Adon's family go through the door when Noah's family went? Mr. Kovacs stopped the story there on purpose. He said the Book names eight souls, and it does not name Adon, and a wise teller leaves the knife on that stone and does not pretend he knows the rest. What he knew, and what he wanted us to know, was simpler. Tall ones walked in real bodies. Watchers left their post on purpose. Giants ate and broke and made the earth unfit, and the Lord gave time, and then He gave water. A boy who ran toward the yard instead of toward the famous names was doing the one kind of brave that still matters when the ridge goes dark.

Mr. Kovacs picked up his thermos. Up above the cabin the pines stood black against what little stars we had, and for a minute they looked again like men standing watch, and then the fire caught the oak I had put on and the light climbed, and they were only pines.

I was fourteen. I walked back to the cabin with my flashlight on the roots so I wouldn't turn an ankle, and I did not tell the others that my grandfather's version and Mr. Kovacs's version had the same bones. I slept in a top bunk under a quilt that smelled like mothballs and woodsmoke, and once in the night I woke and heard the wind moving in those pines, and I named the Lord the way Adon had named Him on the path, and then I slept again.

I still come up here when I can. The cabin rents to anybody now, and the Trail still cuts the ridge, and kids still say giants are a metaphor when they want to sound grown. I let them finish. Then I build the fire up and I tell it straight. The veil gets thin in places people stop expecting. Watchers left their domain once already, and Scripture says they are kept for judgment. Earth has been through one cleansing of that particular evil, and Jesus said the days of Noah would look familiar again before the end. Under a pine I'll only say this: the tall ones walked, a hammer kept time, and a boy ran the right direction with his sister's wrist in his hand.

Go on. Put that other oak on. I like these pines better when the fire's high enough to show me they're trees.

END